

THE COTTON GIN



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In 1793, Eli Whitney traveled south to take up a tutoring post on a plantation. Intrigued by the time-consuming manual labor of separating the sticky seeds from the fibers of short-staple cotton, he designed a simple hand-cranked machine, possibly based on an idea passed on by an enslaved man called Sam. His cotton engine, or “gin,” used rollers to comb the seeds from the fiber, enabling one enslaved person to clean 50lb (23kg) of cotton fiber per day instead of just 1lb (0.5kg) processed by hand. The gin greatly expanded cotton production in the South.

North and South diverge

In 1808, a ban on the importation of slaves—which had been prohibited by the Constitution until that date—became the law. Many Americans hoped slavery would gradually decline. North of the Mason-Dixon Line, states had already passed laws banning or slowly abolishing slavery. The free Black American population grew rapidly in the North, where Black Americans founded their own churches and schools. Many also sheltered runaways from enslavement. Although free, Black Americans in the North faced racism and legal hurdles, preventing full participation in society.

Life in the South was a very different matter. Between 1800 and 1861, the southern United States became the world’s largest and